

Simon Aquino

FORWARD DEPLOYED ENGINEER · PRINCIPAL PLATFORM ENGINEER · AI-NATIVE CLOUD ARCHITECT (AWS/GCP/AZURE)

London, United Kingdom (open to relocation)

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Executive Profile

Forward Deployed Engineer with 16+ years building and running large-scale distributed systems. I embed with client teams and pair technical strategy with hands-on delivery, shipping the infrastructure that matters while raising the level of the engineers around me. Most of my work centres on "Golden Path" Internal Developer Platforms across AWS, Azure, and GCP, and on leaving teams able to run them on their own.

- **Strategic Technical Delivery:** I work with leadership to set the technical roadmap, then build it. That has meant delivering firm-wide infrastructure, such as global Kubernetes fleets managed through GitHub and Helm, tied directly to business goals.
- **Cloud-Native Engineering:** I run large container platforms and extend Kubernetes with custom controllers and Operators in Go and Python to solve multi-tenant and cross-cloud problems.
- **Embedded Enablement & Leadership:** I work alongside engineers as a playing coach, pairing, mentoring, and upskilling teams on CI/CD and modern stacks so the standard holds after I leave.
- **SRE & Operational Resilience:** I build reliability into the platform itself, bringing SRE practices like observability, error budgets, and self-healing so systems stay available under load.

Professional Experience

Haleon

London, UK

ENGINEERING MANAGER, DATA ENGINEERING (VIA CORE ENGINEERING CONSULTING GROUP)

Mar. 2026 - Present

- **Cloud Platform Delivery:** Delivered and managed the infrastructure for a greenfield identity platform using Terraform Cloud, Terraform, Helm, Go, and GitHub Actions, deploying natively onto Azure Kubernetes Service (AKS) under strict regulatory guidelines.
- **Data Architecture & Coding:** Architected and coded a Python/Dagster data ingestion pipeline using the Medallion model (Bronze/Silver/Gold) to process identity and privilege data into Azure Storage and PostgreSQL.
- **Resilient Systems Engineering:** Designed logical schema mappings and data quality outer-joins to handle API eventual consistency, and implemented client-side rate limiting and exponential backoff to handle aggressive HTTP 429 throttling.
- **ORM & Analytical SQL Duality:** Enforced SQLAlchemy ORM for Silver writes and raw SQL CTEs/LEFT JOINS for Gold analytical reports, preventing data drops due to eventual consistency, with complete testing parity using pytest and testcontainers.
- **Compliance & Stakeholder Enablement:** Built automated SOX controls (PA-02/AM-02) and enabled non-technical Product Owners to manage classification rules via version-controlled CSV files, providing a mathematical lineage from report to raw payload.
- **AI-Assisted Delivery:** Introduced the team to Copilot-assisted development and AI-driven code review, shifting the delivery model toward directing and reviewing AI-generated code rather than writing it by hand.

Barclays

London, UK

PRINCIPAL PLATFORM CONSULTANT (VIA RED BADGER)

Oct. 2025 - Mar. 2026

- **Greenfield IDP Engineering:** Architected and built a high-performance Internal Developer Platform (IDP) on AWS and Kubernetes (EKS). Managed configuration via Helm and GitHub, developing "Golden Path" templates in Go/Python that abstract complexity and optimise DevEx.
- **Embedded Workforce Transformation:** Operating as a technical "player-coach" within legacy software teams. I drive Cloud-Native adoption through daily pair programming, upskilling engineers on CI/CD pipelines and SRE best practices to ensure long-term autonomy.
- **High-Stakes Execution:** Technical Authority within the platform team building critical payment rails. Delivering a secure, self-service ecosystem that balances strict financial governance with the agility required for high-throughput data integrations.

Haleon

London, UK

PRINCIPAL CONSULTANT, GITHUB MIGRATION (VIA CORE ENGINEERING CONSULTING GROUP)

Apr. 2025 - Sep. 2025

- **Migration Engineering:** Led the technical delivery of an enterprise GitHub migration.

JPMorgan Chase

London, UK

ENGINEERING MANAGER, CLOUD ENABLEMENT (VIA CORE ENGINEERING CONSULTING GROUP)

Apr. 2023 - Mar. 2025

- **Embedded Scaling & Enablement:** Embedded within the Cloud Enablement team as it grew to 13 engineers over two years. I paired daily with the workforce to establish a "You Build It, You Run It" culture, upskilling teams on SRE best practices and modern cloud-native tech.
- **Enterprise-Scale Kubernetes Architecture:** Architected the firm-wide GCP foundation and Kubernetes ecosystem (100+ clusters). Delivered AI-ready blueprints integrating Vertex AI and data pipelines, enabling secure transition to data-intensive GenAI workloads.
- **Golden Path Engineering:** Engineered a "Golden Path" strategy that abstracted infrastructure complexity using Crossplane and GitOps. Reduced cognitive load and improved DevEx and observability (Prometheus/Grafana) for thousands of internal developers.

- **Hands-on Embedded Leadership:** Embedded as the technical lead for Denmark's critical Property Tax Platform. I actively coded alongside cross-functional engineers, breaking down architectural silos and upskilling the team to own the solution independently.
- **Infrastructure Modernisation:** Audited and executed an infrastructure consolidation strategy for a sprawling estate, simplifying legacy complexity to reduce monthly cloud operational costs on AWS without compromising system performance.
- **API Gateway Re-Engineering:** Eradicated high-risk technical debt by replacing brittle custom authentication with managed AWS API Gateway.

Microsoft, Loveholidays, eBay, Element Insurance, HMRC, Google

London, Berlin, Copenhagen

- **Microsoft (Principal Consultant):** Rescued a stalled on-prem to Azure migration for a major trading platform, optimising AKS/EventHubs for high-frequency throughput and condensing delivery from years to months.
- **Loveholidays (Lead Platform Engineer):** Resolved critical latency bottlenecks in Go/Java microservices on GKE, achieving 30% performance gains through Kubernetes autoscaling optimisation.
- **eBay (Lead DevOps Engineer):** Orchestrated the migration of eBay Classifieds to GCP, architecting standardised GKE workflows for distributed European engineering teams.
- **Earlier Career:** Greenfield AWS/K8s platforms (Element Insurance), UK Gov digital tax at scale (HMRC), and Python/App Engine tooling at Google, earning multiple peer bonuses for code quality.

Skills

Cloud Native Ecosystem	Kubernetes (Expert), AWS, GCP, Azure, Helm, Terraform, Terraform Cloud, Crossplane, GitOps (ArgoCD/Flux), Istio, Internal Developer Platforms (IDP).
Languages & Engineering	Go, Python, React, Java/Spring Boot, Bash, SQL (PostgreSQL), Distributed Systems Design, Event-Driven Architecture, Microservices, API Design (gRPC/REST).
SRE, DevOps & Security	GitHub Actions, CI/CD Pipelines, Prometheus, Grafana, Datadog, Dagster, Data Pipelines (ETL/Medallion), Identity Governance & IAM, SOX Compliance, Zero Trust, Site Reliability Engineering (SRE).
Technical Leadership	Technical Strategy, Pair Programming, Workforce Upskilling, Developer Experience (DevEx), Team Building & Scaling, Stakeholder Management, "Golden Path" Architecture, FinOps.

Education

University of Bristol

Bristol, UK

Languages

English	C2 - Native / Bilingual Proficiency
Italian	C2 - Native / Bilingual Proficiency
German	B2 - Professional Working Proficiency
Danish	A2 - Elementary Proficiency

Certificates

2025	Google Cloud Platform (GCP) , Professional Cloud Architect (PCA)
2025	Google Cloud Platform (GCP) , Generative AI Leader
2015	Scrum Alliance , Certified ScrumMaster (CSM)
2014	UK Government , UK Security Clearance (SC) [Previous]
2014	Red Hat , Red Hat Certified System Administrator (RHCSA)
2013	VMware , Certified Advanced Professional 5 - Data Centre Admin (VCAP5-DCA)
2013	VMware , Certified Professional 5 - Data Centre Virtualisation (VCP5-DV)
2011	Google , Python Readability (Internal Code Quality Award)